Two years of the ELIXIR-UK Fellowship

Empowering Minds: Professionalising UK Data Stewardship in Life Sciences

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The project behind the Fellowship

In 2021, ELIXIR-UK was granted a UKRI award for the ELIXIR-UK DaSH project. The University of Bradford leads the project with a delivery team at Cardiff University, the Earlham Institute, the University of Manchester, and the University of Oxford.

The project aims to embed Research Data Management (RDM) know-how into UK universities and institutes by producing and delivering training in Data Stewardship. It focuses on building capacity and professionalising the role of Data Stewards while leveraging the local expertise within diverse UK research-performing organisations.

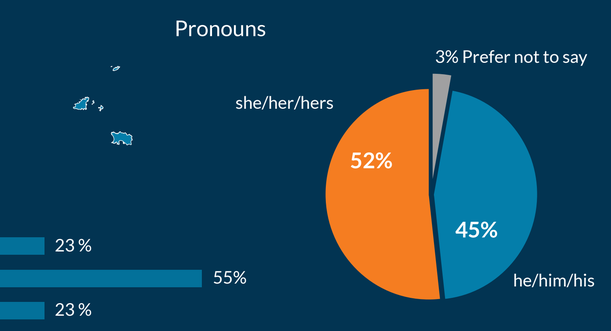
Ultimately, the project aims to create a culture change with a Fellowship of Data Stewards. Fellows will act as ambassadors to embed RDM for the life sciences in their organisations.

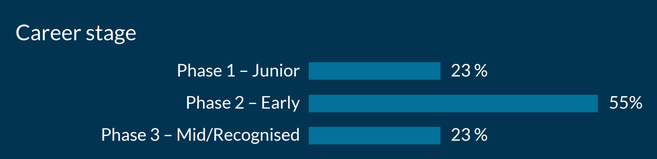
The Fellowship in numbers

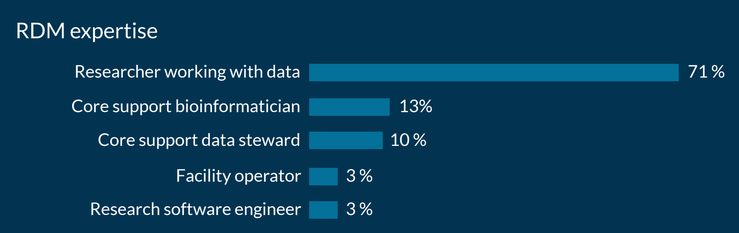
Since its inception, the Fellowship has grown from 9 successful applicants to a total of 24.

1st cohort – 9

2nd cohort – 15



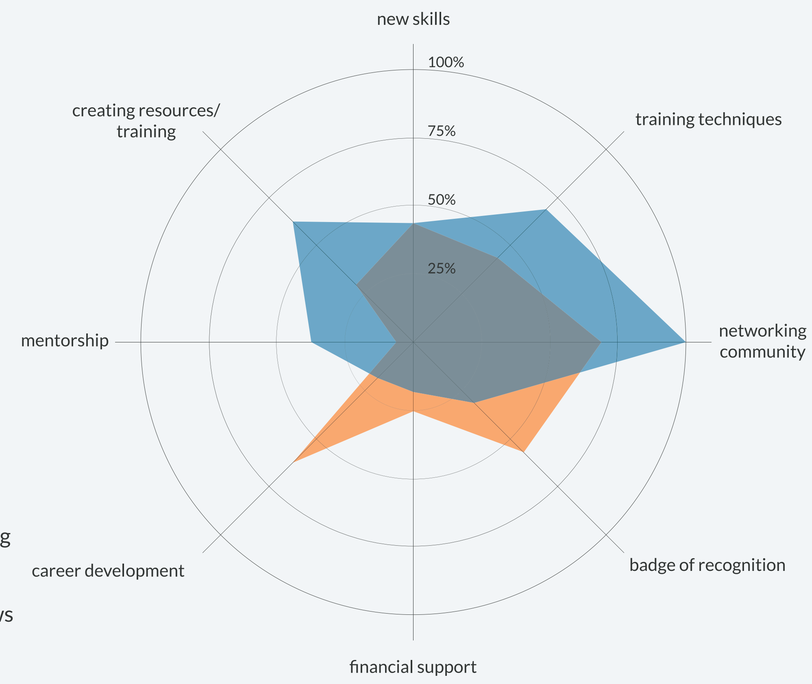




Reasons to apply vs the benefits current Fellows have experienced

Recently, we've explored the reasons to apply and the benefits that Fellows are experiencing as part of the programme. This data will help sustain the Fellowship for future rounds and enhance the offer to meet the needs of current and prospective Fellows.

- Reasons to apply
- Benefits experienced



Unexpected benefits

Creating resources and training materials

Being part of the Fellowship entails creating and organising training courses, developing guidelines, and contributing to ELIXIR resources such as the RDMkit, FAIRCookbook, TeSS, FAIRsharing or the Data Stewardship Wizard. Fellows have stated they are interested in creating together "publicly accessible content to stop remaking the wheel."

Despite not being vital for applicants, Fellows have shown a strong interest and motivation to contribute to key international resources and create materials to build capacity in RDM locally.

Gaining and improving training skills

One of the Fellowship's key benefits is the ELIXIR Train the Trainer (TtT). Delivered at the start of the programme, it brings the expertise of several ELIXIR members not only in the UK but across other Nodes. The TtT was attended by nearly **90% of all Fellows**, even those with a background in academic education.

While this aspect was not particularly important for candidates to apply, it was observed as a significant impact that Fellows have experienced.

Mentorship

In January 2023, we announced our mentorship programme, a new feature of the Fellowship, providing advice in specific RDM domains and pedagogical best practices. This new benefit was unavailable for Fellows in both cohorts at the beginning of their programmes. We decided to start it after our experience supporting the first cohort.

Benefits we delivered beyond expectations

Networking and community

SSI's experience in community engagement has paved the way to building a sense of community, mentoring and advising the coordination team with more than ten years of experience managing the successful SSI Fellowship.

As a result, we've exceeded expectations in this arena. Networking was the second most important reason to apply, and we delivered beyond Fellows' expectations. We've offered drop-in sessions, community calls, ELIXIR-UK mentors, ELIXIR-UK working groups, in-person retreats or event sponsorship for events like the ELIXIR All Hands.

In addition, some Fellows are already getting involved in the ELIXIR RDM Community, a hub for know-how exchange and development of training in RDM.

Benefits with room for improvement

Badge of recognition

While we welcome professionals who work with data in the life sciences at any career stage, a panel of experts scrutinises applications. All candidates must not only demonstrate a strong understanding of data management in their fields, but have excellent communication and team working skills. Only some can pass this thorough selection process, already recognising Fellows' skills and experience.

Some Fellows from the first cohort have already experienced the benefit of holding the ELIXIR-UK badge of recognition when discussing RDM at their organisations. After being selected, they had a stronger voice in meetings, a motto we have adopted in our outreach: ***"Trust me, I'm an ELIXIR-UK Fellow."***

However, we still have room for improvement to elevate Fellows' work and stories. For instance, we plan on showcasing their successes through official ELIXIR-UK channels more prominently.

Career development

While this benefit has been one of the main drivers to apply, we cannot expect to reap the benefits in less than two years.

Nevertheless, we've already observed two Fellows that have benefited from being part of the programme in their career progress with recent promotions and PhD opportunities.

Financial support

We are aware of the current struggles for professionals in research and academia taking on activities without financial reward or independence. We, therefore, offer small honorariums for Fellows' time invested in the activities of this Fellowship.

Although it may seem we are not delivering as expected in this area, we are on track. Fellows only receive their honorariums after completing their tasks. We expect most of our community to benefit significantly in this area by June 2023, after attending and reporting on several conferences and meetings, and delivering new pieces of training.

What's new

Started a mentorship scheme

In 2023, we recruited 12 mentors from our pool of ELIXIR-UK experts to help Fellows create their training materials. Mentors provide not only advice in specific RDM domains but also pedagogical best practices.

Munazah Andrabi *University of Manchester*
Robert Andrews *Cardiff University*
Emily Angiolini *Earlham Institute*
Wendi Bacon *The Open University*
Tim Beck *University of Leicester*
Alexia Cardona *University of Cambridge*
Nick Juty *University of Manchester*
Katarzyna Kamieniecka *University of Bradford*
Allyson Lister *University of Oxford*
Philippe Rocca-Serra *University of Oxford*
Ralf Weber *University of Birmingham*
Martin Wolstencroft *University of Bradford*

Built bridges with other initiatives

- **eScience Centre in the Netherlands** – delivered a joint workshop on building champions programmes at the SSI's Collaborations Workshop 2023
- **ELIXIR-NL** – regularly meeting to discuss experiences that will help implement a Fellowship of Data Stewards in the NL
- **ELIXIR RDM Community** and its RDM Trainers Network
- **RDA FAIRsharing WG, ELIXIR RDA Community, ELIXIR Interoperability and Training Platforms**

Sponsored Fellows at key events

- 2 Fellows at the SSI's Collaborations Workshop 2023
- 5 Fellows at the Bioinformatics Educations Summit 2023
- 4 Fellows at the ELIXIR All Hands 2023

Launched an official Fellowship website

The Fellowship now has a GitHub-hosted website using the ELIXIR Toolkit Jekyll theme. We aim to use bioschemas markup across the site so that materials and events automatically appear on TeSS.

The site aims to recognise Fellows and Mentors that contributed to resources, training and events, and assist in communicating our work and sharing resources at Fellows' organisations.

Scan me to visit the new site
fellowship.elixiruknode.org

Developed more training materials

- **FAIR Pointers** – a short Carpentries-style course tackling FAIR data's basic concepts and terminology. This is an introductory course, and no prior knowledge is necessary.
- **Coffee, Biscuits and Data** – an awareness workshop to involve all professionals in research-performing organisations. This playful session aims to demystify RDM and illustrate that almost all life science professionals are involved in the data life cycle.
- **Kept releasing RDM bites** – Bites of content in the form of videos to train in basic and specialised research data management aspects

This project is funded by the UKRI Innovation Scholars: Data Science Training in Health and Bioscience call (DaSH). (MR/V038966/1)

ELIXIR ALL HANDS MEETING 2023
DUBLIN, IRELAND